

within the first month. That's not entirely careless spending; it was a good investment.

Money Mistake: *Your Kids Think They Don't Have to Work*

The Fix: *Help Your Teenager Find a Job*

A spoiled, pampered kid isn't helping anyone—including him- or herself. Your children need a job as soon as they're old enough to work. Even young teenagers should find ways to be employed (part time, of course, and not in a way that interferes with school). Every job will give your kid a new experience and perspective, both the good and the bad.

In my teens and early 20s, I did many backbreaking jobs that made me appreciate the value of hard-earned cash and a well-chosen career. Perhaps it comes as a surprise to you that I'm no stranger to manual labor. The summer I turned 17, I got hired by a logging company to go out into the wilderness and replant trees where the logging company had hacked them down the year before. I'd walk down a row with a shovel, stuff a seedling into a hole, push down the earth around it and move on to the next one ... hour after hour. It was strenuous work. We carried our quota of trees on our backs, the blazing sun beating down on us and the mosquitoes and blackflies eating us alive. Some guys wore thick mosquito nets, which made the work even hotter. We were paid by the tree, which meant you could only make a lot of money if you were agile and exact. It also meant the less-honest workers tried to cheat the system. I watched guys try to plant two or five trees at once to get rid of their seedlings and get paid for greater output. Of course, the managers were hip to all the scams. If they saw that you'd planted two trees in a hole, you got one free pass, in case it was an accident. If they caught you doing it again, you were outta there.

I learned plenty of life lessons at that job. I learned if I wasn't quick and competitive, I wouldn't make a lot of cash. I also learned that cheating is no way to get ahead. I made close to \$5,000 that summer. For a kid, that was pretty good. But I didn't go back the